

Rhetorical Hermeneutics: Invention and Interpretation in the Age of Science. Ed. Alan G. Gross and William M. Keith. Albany: State University of New York Press, 1997.

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Rhetorical Hermeneutics revisits a memorable exchange in the 1993 *Southern Communication Journal* (SCJ) between Dilip Gaonkar and a handful of other rhetoricians of science. This edited collection, which leaves the SCJ exchange basically intact, makes two significant additions to the original debate between Gaonkar (part 1 of this collection) and a half-dozen dissenters (part 2): Five additional critics extend Gaonkar's essay in various directions (part 3). Then Thomas Farrell reflects on the contributions and, in a separate essay, Gaonkar replies to his critics (part 4). Overall, Gaonkar's critique marks a significant, reflexive moment in the history of contemporary rhetorical studies. However, although the core set of essays that constitute parts 1 and 2 has been revised and strengthened, *Rhetorical Hermeneutics* does not contribute greatly to our overall understanding of what the original problem is all about. As such, those readers already familiar with the original discussion in SCJ will not be missing a lot by opting to pass on this new and expanded collection of essays.

Although Gaonkar's critique of neo-Aristotelianism is ambitious and resists brief summary (89), it is also easily grasped in terms of a struggle over a single word (190). That word is *rhetoric*, a word that Gaonkar says is everywhere nowadays. It is not only that a number of critics draw explicitly on rhetorical analysis, Gaonkar says, but that these same critics also seem to find a host of other critics and philosophers using rhetoric too, albeit "implicitly" (74). To the charge that none of the implicit rhetoricians has ever claimed to be using rhetoric, the explicit rhetoricians respond by defining rhetoric as a transparent art that persuades without seeming to do so. By defining rhetoric broadly enough to include a variety of textual practices, the explicit rhetoricians thus create an opening for rhetoric to go by other names, such as deconstruction (230). But Gaonkar claims that by confusing a metadiscourse like deconstruction for rhetoric, the explicit rhetoricians fail to stake a claim for the distinctiveness of rhetoric itself. When attributed to others so "promiscuously" (37-38), Gaonkar attests, rhetoric as a method loses its specificity. The end result is what he calls rhetoric's "globalization" (29-33).

Gaonkar does not have a problem with globalization itself but with the ability of the classical lexicon to support a contemporary interpretive practice. Distinguishing between *production* and *interpretation*, Gaonkar charges that rhetoric is essentially a productive art but is now being used as an interpretive art. Because an interpretive process "is not a simple reversal of the process of production," Gaonkar claims, one cannot unproblematically translate an

Aristotelian vocabulary designed for generating speeches into an interpretive, hermeneutical vocabulary. Gaonkar's more serious charge, however, is that the performative lexicon is just too "thin" and "abstract" (33): Ethos, pathos, and logos are found in every text. When faced with a rhetorical interpretation such as Alan Gross's, Gaonkar explains its insightfulness not in terms of the power of the critic's rhetorical metadiscourse to locate an object's intrinsic rhetoricity but as a by-product of the critic's interpretation (29). Put another way, the master interpreter as globalizer will find a "thinly" specified rhetoric everywhere. Thus, Gaonkar argues that the interpretive turn in rhetorical studies and the process of globalization are related because the contemporary rhetorical critic is no longer producing arguments so much as (re)interpreting them and (re)claiming them for rhetoric.

Although Gaonkar contends that the classical vocabulary lacks explanatory power, he also admits that it can be refashioned and perhaps also combined with other, "thicker" metadiscourses (e.g., feminism, Marxism, deconstruction, psychoanalysis, etc.). In fact, he says that such a translation effort is already under way (32), as Gross also attests in his use of Habermas as a methodological supplement to Aristotle (144). Unfortunately, and this is Gaonkar's most serious charge of all, the attempt to "thicken" the classical lexicon does not rid rhetorical criticism of an ideology rooted in the classical notion of the citizen:

a view of speaker as the seat of origin rather than a point of articulation, a view of strategy as identifiable under an intentional description, a view of discourse as constitutive of character and community, a view of audience positioned simultaneously as "spectator" and "participant," and finally, a view of "ends" that binds speaker, strategy, discourse, and audience in a web of purposive actions. (32)

To this "intentionalist," agent-centered view of discourse, Gaonkar (in unwavering devotion to binary thinking) opposes an "intertextual" view. Whereas the former defers the textual object by turning it into an effect of the writer's strategic design (332), the latter takes into account what John Campbell calls the "cultural grammar," in which textual object, author, and critic are situated (53-54). As far as Gaonkar is concerned, an intentionalist strategy "cannot unlock the grammar of massive social formations such as 'modern science' that are propelled by 'system imperatives' " (337-38) nor can it show how discourse "is produced and populated with significations within a matrix of technologies—literary, social, and material—that elude the reach and the imprint of the subject" (337). To see Darwin, for example, "as a Super Rhetor, bestriding history like a strategic colossus" (128), fails to account, Gaonkar argues, for *The Origin of Species* as a discourse articulated at the intersection of a number of competing, institutional frameworks.

Gaonkar attempts to demonstrate the general applicability of his critique to twentieth-century rhetorical studies by drawing on a hard case: the rhetoric of science. Because science is considered most resistant to charges of rhetoric-

ity, it represents a kind of final frontier for rhetoricians, according to Gaonkar, as they attempt to recuperate implicit rhetoric where it is not even supposed to exist. Drawing on three case studies, Gaonkar attempts to show not only how "our critical studies are sustained by the vocabulary of classical rhetoric" but how the classical, agent-centered vocabulary is "primarily fashioned for directing performance rather than facilitating understanding" (32).

In the first case study, Gaonkar takes John Campbell to task for his "intentionalist" stance in his early work on Darwin. It is only in Campbell's most recent work that Gaonkar finds Campbell "positioned differently," situating Darwin in a complex, intertextual web of voices, empirical findings, and larger social forces (58). In the second case study, Gaonkar implicitly criticizes the "thinness" of the classical lexicon by drawing on Alan Gross's *The Rhetoric of Science*. Gaonkar presumes to get around Gross's rhetorical reading of *Narratio Prima* by accusing Gross of not being rhetorical at all but constructivist, social scientific rather than Aristotelian. Gaonkar calls Gross's neo-Aristotelianism a "phantom; it does not exist" (64). In the third case study, Gaonkar analyzes Lawrence Prelli's topical approach to scientific discourse. After calling Prelli's approach "an endlessly complex affair" (67), Gaonkar concludes that it is too thin and (insofar as it "translates a scientific paper from one idiom to another" [69]) lacks explanatory power.

In part 2, "Dissensions," six rhetorical critics, including Campbell and Gross (but not Prelli), respond to Gaonkar's charges. In less than a dozen pages, Michael Leff dismantles everything in Gaonkar's argument except for the nagging question of agency. Leff's essay, like the essays by Campbell, Gross, McCloskey, Miller, and Willard, quite easily sees right through Gaonkar's rather elaborate binary system. By using the classical notion of *imitatio* as his guide, Leff shows how production and interpretation in ancient times were not opposites but "interacted with one another" (98). According to Leff, "imitatio requires a dynamic balance between interpretation and production" (98). In her response to Gaonkar, Carolyn Miller also deconstructs the production/interpretation distinction. But Miller's response differs from Leff's insofar as Miller also calls into question Gaonkar's understanding of "translation" as simply a matter of "lexical matching" (166). Just as interpretation is wrapped up in production and vice versa, so too, Miller argues, is interpretation part of the work of translating Aristotelian or other concepts between cultures.

Miller, Leff, and colleagues also respond to Gaonkar's critique of classical rhetoric as too agent-oriented to account for scientific communication. Miller responds to the charge that neo-Aristotelian terminology necessarily involves an ideology of human agency by suggesting that we might blame the strong sense of Aristotelian agency on our modern, positivist translators. Moreover, Miller also suggests that "we can understand rhetorical action as a function that is both intended and governed" (159). Thus, Miller implies that Gaonkar's distinction between *intentional* and *intertextual* is artificial. The other five critics who respond to Gaonkar are in implicit agreement here. Leff,

for example, contrasts Gaonkar's reading of Campbell with a more fluid reading, one that is both intentional and intertextual (95). In his response, Campbell also suggests that an intentionalist reading can complement an intertextual reading—both kinds of readings do not have to be mutually exclusive: "We can recognize that from different perspectives the speaker can be described accurately one way or the other or as a tensional fusion of both" (123). Finally, Gross makes a similar claim in his response, when he finds Aristotle and Habermas complementary, but not Aristotle and Latour, because the latter dissolves human actors into their instruments (144). Thus, the rhetorical critics do not concede to Gaonkar so much as they create a space in which the rhetorical and structural traditions can coexist (226).

The rhetorical critics also respond to Gaonkar's critique of agency by insisting on the centrality of the author. "What Gaonkar has called an 'ideology,' " Campbell says, "is the necessary background assumption under which communication, including his own, is intelligible and perhaps possible" (121). Ironically, Gaonkar provides Campbell with the evidence for this claim to the extent that Campbell finds Gaonkar attributing agency to Gross, Prelli, and himself. According to Campbell, Gaonkar's "critique of me recapitulates my critique of Darwin" (114), which is to imply that Gaonkar is working in the very same humanist tradition he disavows. In his response, Charles Willard relies on a similar strategy that finds Gaonkar playing an Aristotelian realist on the lookout for a conception of science free from rhetoric. Thus, "Aristotle's rhetoric is being put in its place by Aristotle's philosophy" (182), a view implied by Deirdre McCloskey, who in her response also finds something troubling about Gaonkar's search for an arhetorical "reference" or "reality" (111). Willard also replies to Gaonkar's critique by noting matter-of-factly that dialectic and rhetoric share the same subject matter, "human agency" (189). In their replies, then, the rhetorical critics insist, as Thomas Farrell does in his postscript to this collection, on the inevitability of human agency in any hermeneutical metadiscourse (323).

In part 3, "Extensions," Gaonkar's critique of contemporary rhetorical criticism is drawn out in various directions by critics such as David Kaufer, Steve Fuller, and Andrew King. But whereas part 2 builds a referentially rich and focused interplay of meanings, part 3 has difficulty staying focused, not because of the quality of individual essays but because reflexivity occasionally lapses into an uncritical devotion to an intentionalist model. (The essays by James Jasinski and William Keith are exceptions.) Perhaps part of the difficulty here is definitional because a few of the essays in part 3 are not unproblematic "extensions" (either of Gaonkar's critique or his intertextual solution). One has to wonder, as I did while reading part 3, whether Gaonkar succeeded at all in making rhetorical studies any more reflexive about its rhetorical practices. On the other hand, it is also not clear to what extent Gaonkar, who replies to his critics in part 4, takes heed of the well-placed criticisms from the rhetoricians in part 2. In his second essay, Gaonkar makes a number of small concessions (most notably to Leff [341] and Miller [346]),

although he continues to insist on the ideology of human agency that he finds implicated in the classical tradition. As a kind of all-purpose response (see 332, 337, 346, 348, 351), the critique of agency works to excuse or weaken the other charges (i.e., the translation problem, "thinness," the production-oriented vocabulary). But unlike his other criticisms, the agency critique just will not seem to go away—and perhaps rightly so.

Although the rhetorical critics in part 2 do a good job of responding to Gaonkar, I came away from this collection feeling as though Gaonkar's critique of agency warrants continued reflexive action on our part, especially when it comes to accounting for such disciplinary buzzwords as *purpose*, *audience*, *context*, *discourse*, *writer*, and *occasion*. If we continue to understand communication—technical, scientific, literary, business, and so forth—in terms of strategic speakers and writers only, then we simply fail to see how, at least "in the case of science," communication is (also) "institutionally driven" (337). To the extent that Gaonkar makes us more aware of the relationships between actors and institutions, his critique is a must-read. It will be interesting to see what becomes of it as the process of refashioning a rhetorical lexicon continues.

However, it is also important to note that *Rhetorical Hermeneutics* is not primarily concerned with scientific communication but with ethics of rhetorical reading. Clearly, then, there are genre issues—not only among scientific and nonscientific forms of writing but also among the writing practices of various scientific disciplines—that the collection fails to address because of its focus on the interpretive turn in rhetorical studies. This broad focus also means that Gaonkar can be very selective in his redescription of rhetoric of science as interpretive and mainly concerned with the past (e.g., *Narratio Prima*, *Origin*). The notion of rhetoric of science as present-oriented and prescriptive (as well as interpretive/productive) is only mentioned briefly by Fuller (295), and not in the service of a critique of Gaonkar's understanding of rhetoric of science. Those readers looking for a more informed discussion of rhetoric of science, one that does not reduce key figures like Charles Bazerman to a footnote (80n19) or try to account for twentieth-century rhetorical criticism as a whole, will need to go elsewhere.

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This winter semester I found myself sitting with a group of graduate students who wanted to know what, how, and where to publish in rhetoric and composition. We were participating in a seminar on academic publishing, a type of gathering that is becoming fairly common in graduate programs around the country. As these students asked me questions ("What kinds of